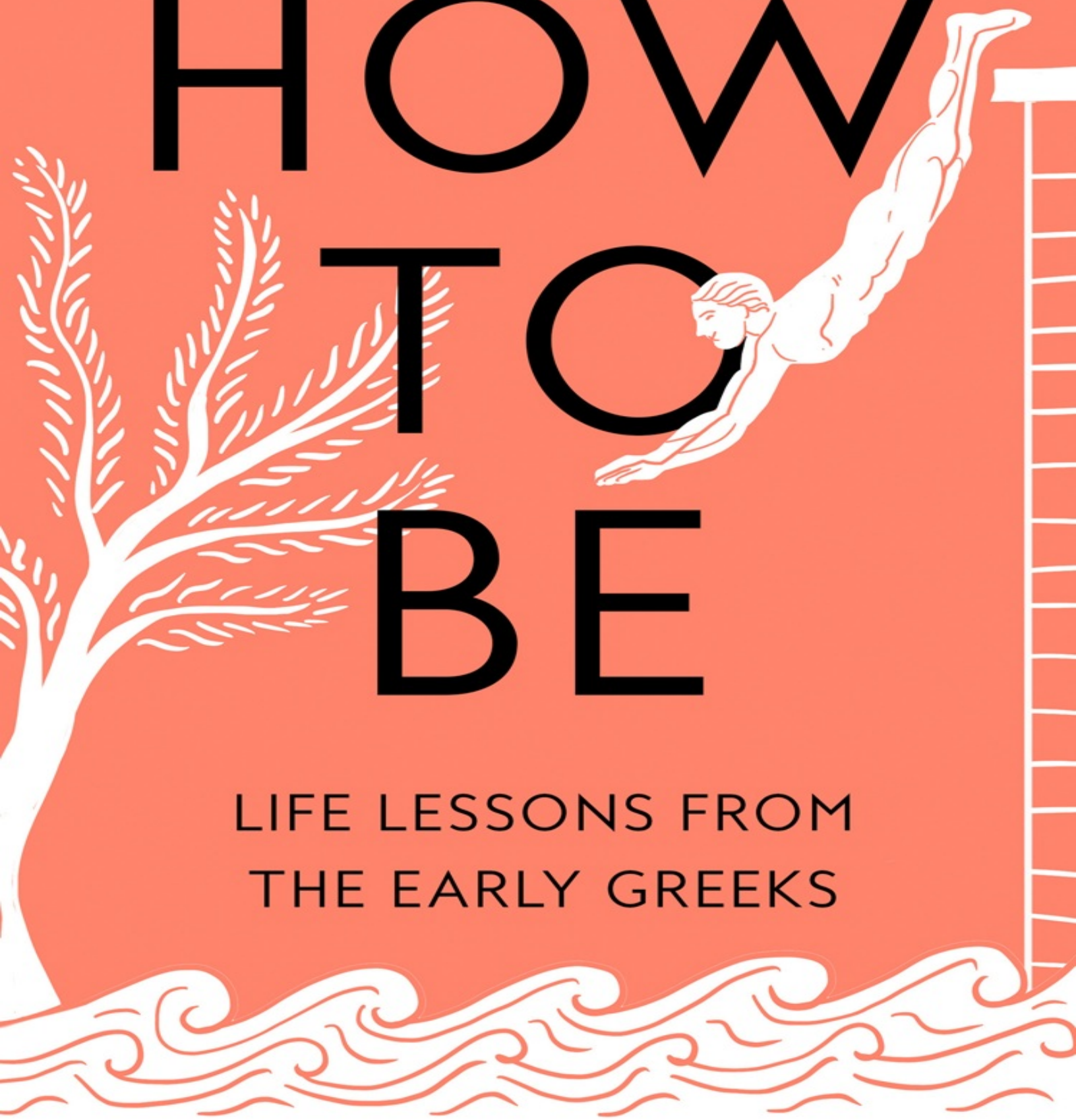


ADAM NICOLSON

HOW TO BE

LIFE LESSONS FROM
THE EARLY GREEKS



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Adam Nicolson



A dynamic sea: the currents of the Mediterranean, as synthesised by NASA from a combination of satellite and in-ocean data.



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INTRODUCTION:

PHILOSOPHY HAS A GEOGRAPHY

This book, which is about the first stirrings of philosophical thinking among the Iron Age Greeks, began a few years ago at sea in the eastern Aegean. My wife Sarah and I were in Samos early one summer and had tied up for the evening at a small quay somewhere on the south coast. Other boats had come in after us, laying their anchors over ours. It happens in busy harbours. And so, first thing in the morning, at first light, with the air as pale as the harbour water, and only the cats awake, I jumped off into its lime-green blue and swam down the 12 feet or so to the sandy sea floor, hand over hand and link by link down the chain, looking for the tangle that needed to be undone.

In one dive after another, I picked up the later anchors, setting them aside. Three dives were enough for ours to lie clear. I was soon back on board, dripping and cold, a towel and then a jersey around me, the engine running quietly under the deck. Whispering to each other so as not to disturb our neighbours, we raised and stowed our anchor and freed the warps from the quay.

With scarcely a wake behind us, we left the harbour, pulled slowly out into the sea south of the island and turned east towards the channel between Samos and the great bulk of Mount Mycale on the Turkish mainland. As the first of the sun touched the tips and vertebrae of mountain and island, we cut the engine, raised the sails, winched them in, felt the hull of the boat starting to lift and surge on its way. We tacked at the far end of Samos, freed the sheets, set the boat on a reach and made for Chios, 50 miles away in the haze. The shadows and ghosts of the blue-grey islands and headlands lay around us all day, as calm as a family of sleeping lions. The Aegean sang and swept beneath us as we took the helm in turn and dozed in turn, heeled over in that wind, driving north and west in the blue and glitter of life.

The whole day felt like a dose of happiness, a moment of suspension, both transient and unexpected, when this earth and this life seemed not only to be wonderful, replete with beauty and grace, but astonishingly, almost overwhelmingly whole, undisturbed by the news-and-noise of daily existence, or any sense of hurry.

I had with me an old and battered copy of a book Sarah's father, who had taught Greek at King's College, Cambridge, had co-authored with his friend Geoffrey Kirk in

the 1950s. *The Presocratic Philosophers* by G. S. Kirk and J. E. Raven has been for many generations the guidebook to the beginnings of western thought. Carefully, in both Greek and English, the two friends outlined the first emergence 2,500 years ago of the instinct that understanding was not simply to be learned from priests or elders, or experts, or by imagining a congeries of terrifying metaphysical monsters, but could be gathered by each of us applying the worrying and thinking mind to the conundrums of life. Questions come rippling out of their pages. What is the underlying structure of things? what lasts? what is constant in a world of flux? what is identity? or substance? what is the relationship of thought to world? what is being? what value? what justice? And, in the light of any answers to those questions, how should we be? How should we treat each other?

I never knew John Raven. He died ten years before I met his daughter. But it is one of the miracles of books that through their pages you can start to know a man decades after his death. I could, in a way, hear him and converse with him through his printed words. And as we sailed through the Aegean that day, and as I looked at the chart beside me, I began to ask why this eruption of new thinking had happened in this place and at that time. Almost in view from the cockpit of our small chartered boat was the whole province in which Greek philosophy had begun. Those grey-blue masses of island and mainland hid within them the thinkers' cities. Thirty or forty miles to the south in Miletus was the birthplace of the first theorists of the physical world. Twenty miles to the east in Ephesus was the home of Heraclitus, the first person to consider the interrelatedness of things. Just to the north, in the twin cities of Notion and Colophon, was the country of Xenophanes, the first philosopher of civility. Just over the horizon was Lesbos, the island of Sappho and Alcaeus, the greatest early lyric poets. To the south in Samos, the birthplace of Pythagoras, the man who first imagined an everlasting soul and who when exiled to southern Italy took this intellectual revolution to a new and western Greek world, where it flowered again in surprising and radical forms.

That wonderful day's sailing was the invitation to which this book is an answer. It is an exploration of the sea-and-city world in which, in the western tradition, the great and everlasting questions of existence were first explored. What I have written is grounded in a double belief: first that places give access to minds, however distant and strange, that philosophy has a geography and that to be in the places these thinkers knew, visit their cities, sail their seas and find their landscapes not overwhelmed by the millennia that have passed is to know something about them that cannot be found otherwise; and second that, despite that locatedness, and despite their age, the frame of mind of these first thinkers remains astonishingly and surprisingly illuminating today. Read them and you will find your way of seeing the world refreshed and renewed, as if you had bathed one cool morning in a different sea.

Metaphysical philosophy, that branch of thought which deals with the first principles of things, the nature of being and knowing, is, as Bertrand Russell wrote in an early essay,

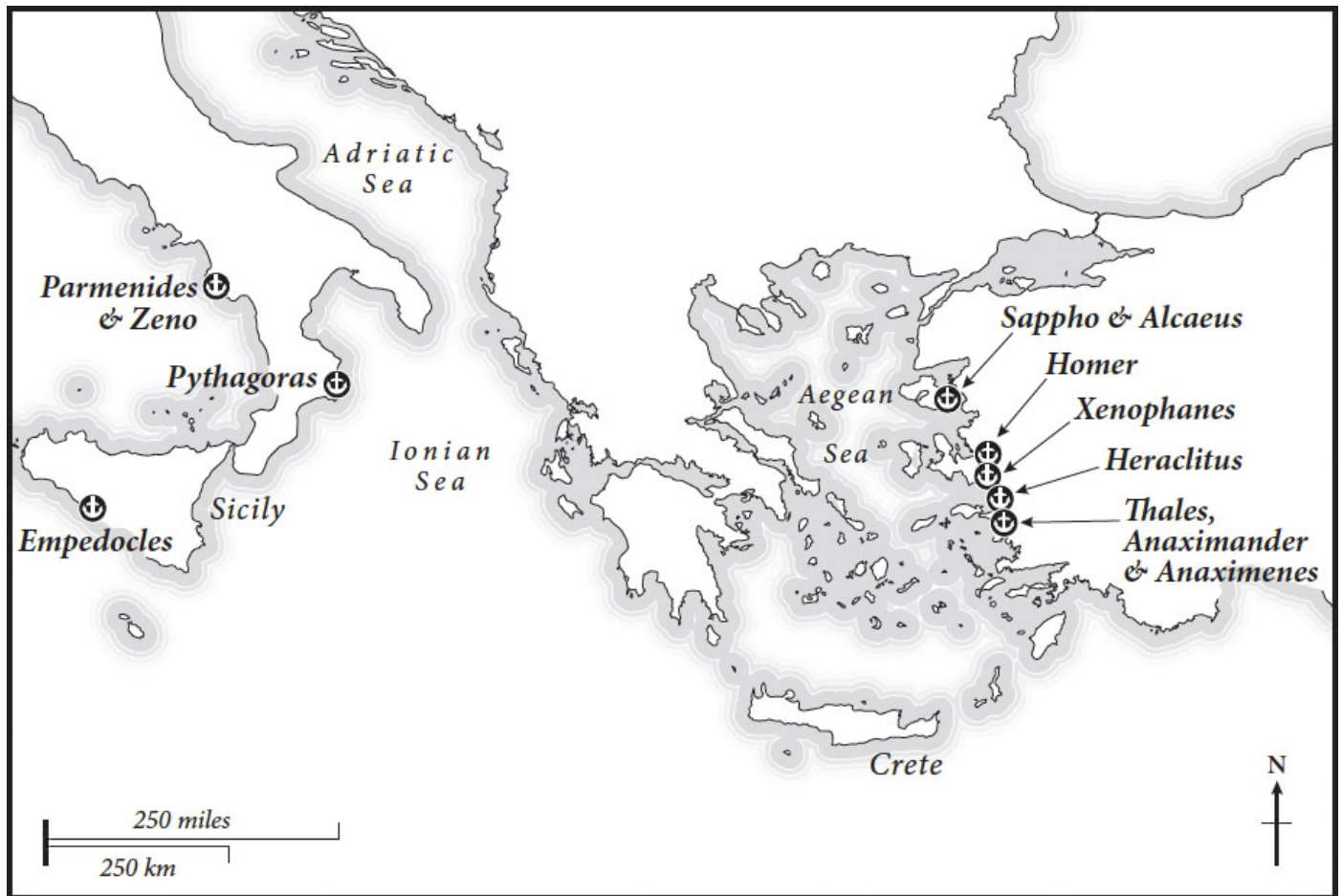
[‘the attempt to conceive](#) the world as a whole’. Philosophy had not begun, he added, as an act of intellectual exclusion but had ‘developed, from the first, by the union and conflict of two very different human impulses, the one urging men towards mysticism, the other urging them towards science’. Russell thought that super-rationalists – he named the eighteenth-century Edinburgh philosopher David Hume – may have achieved greatness through science and analysis alone and others such as Hume’s younger contemporary William Blake through deep mystic insight.

[But the greatest](#) men who have been philosophers have felt the need both of science and of mysticism: the attempt to harmonise the two was what made their life, and what always must, for all its arduous uncertainty, make philosophy, to some minds, a greater thing than either science or religion.

That meeting of impulses is what defines philosophy. Its place is to bridge the transition between the perception of a universal harmony and the daily encounter with the world as it is, in all its difficulty and multiplicity. Both aspects of human experience seem real and yet contradictory. How do they connect? How to reconcile a sense of the whole with the experience of dividedness, the chaos and mutability of things?

These first Greek thinkers, teaching and writing between about 650 and 450 BC, found their life on that boundary. They did not provide a set of rationalist solutions nor of religious doctrines, but again and again explored the borderland between those ways of seeing, holding their position in the shadowy ground between the poetic and the analytic, the physical and metaphysical.

The heart of their approach, in one thinker after another, was not assertion but enquiry, a shuttling between thinking and imagining, and so perhaps should not be called philosophy – the love of wisdom – as if wisdom were a commodity to be taken down off a shelf, but the more troubled and anxious *zetosophy*, the search for wisdom.



The harbour minds of archaic Greece.

That focus on the uncertain, engaging with the unknown other, was common to every one of these Greek thinkers. This book makes a suggestion: their emphasis on fluidity, on interchange and connectedness, derived from their emergence in the great port cities of the Iron Age Aegean, in the period of Greek history known conventionally by historians as the archaic. They lived in a fluid world and thought with a harbour mind. Their cities' lives were dependent on the sea and on the connections the sea could provide, so that this version of Greece in the centuries between 700 and 500 BC was not land-based. It essentially existed at sea and, where it touched the land, it appeared and manifested itself as the cities from which these philosophers came.

Early philosophy is a harbour phenomenon, a by-product of trading hubs on the margins of Asia, on the islands, and eventually in the rich lands of Sicily and southern Italy. What we think of now as the mainland of Greece, then filled with communities of farmer-warriors, played no part in this. The creators of the philosophical revolution were from the mobile edges, merchants in ideas, people from communities in which exchange was the medium of significance and for whom inherited belief was not enough.

That condition is their lasting value. We may want fixed answers but, along with these great and inspiring early minds, we must know in the end to stay afloat, stay with the questions and entertain doubt as the unlikely bedrock of understanding.